

NIRBHAY KAPADIA

BJP EYES A HAT TRICK OF SWEEPS

BEYOND PM MODI'S POPULARITY, A WELL-OILED GOVERNMENT AND PARTY MACHINERY HAS CEMENTED THE PARTY'S INVINCIBILITY IN GUJARAT

By Jumana Shah

As the mercury inches up daily in Gujarat this summer, so does the frenetic activity on the ground for the BJP before the Lok Sabha polls. State BJP president C.R. Paatil and Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel have been criss-crossing the state, addressing three to four gatherings of booth worker committees in a day. Their goal is to connect with over 7.4 million members of the page committee—five chosen voters amongst the 30 on each page of the state's electoral roll comprise a 'page committee'—before the large rallies of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah, also the candidate from Gandhinagar, take place. The target for the BJP is to garner 500,000 votes on each seat this time; the maths translates to 370 more votes for the party in each booth than it had got in 2019.

BJP announced all 26 candidates by mid-March; the Congress could not finalise its 24 candidates till mid-April. The AAP has fielded candidates on two seats—Bhavnagar and Bharuch—as part of the INDIA alliance.

In 2014, Gujarat contributed all its 26 seats to the BJP's tally of 282 seats, and again put its total trust in the BJP in 2019. As the state votes in a single phase on May 7, early estimates predict another clean sweep. In the assembly election in December 2022, the party cornered 156 seats with a 52.5 per cent vote share. The collective vote share of Congress and AAP was 40.2 per cent. With Modi's popularity casting a giant shadow over the political space in Gujarat, the one overriding emotion for the voter is the privilege of voting for a Gujarati PM. This sentiment of Gujarati *asmita* (pride) is the main reason for the BJP's invincibility in Modi and Shah's home state.

However, the BJP's success story in Gujarat is backed with nuanced strategy and flexible decisions—all of it magnified by the failure of the Congress or any other party to provide a credible alternative for over three decades. "The question is why should one not vote for BJP and there is no convincing answer. Unemployment is a concern, but the Congress is unable to present a solution. Saving democracy is not voters' primary concern," says Amit Dholakia, head of the department of political science at MS University, Baroda.

The Congress, moreover, has failed to